

GOODBYE AMERICA, VIA THE SCENIC (FREE) ROUTE

After 40 days chasing the World Cup across North America, the Diary's **final stop** is New York's free ferry — and one last look at Lady Liberty before the flight home.

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Forty days disappear quickly. The final day in America was spent on land, at sea and in the sky, as if the journey wanted one last reminder of how vast the country really is.

The morning began with a short bus ride, then a hop on New York's famous subway to the Whitehall Terminal. From there, like hundreds of budget-conscious tourists every hour, the Diary boarded the Staten Island Ferry. Why pay USD26 to sail to Liberty Island when New York offers a free alternative?

The trick is wonderfully simple. Stand on the starboard side while leaving Manhattan and Lady Liberty remains alongside for almost 15 minutes. On the return journey,

switch sides and enjoy another quarter of an hour with America's most recognisable landmark. The ferry was packed beyond comfort, but almost nobody was travelling to Staten Island. The moment the boat docked, passengers simply walked off, joined the queue for the next ferry, and repeated the journey in reverse.

The Statue of Liberty deserved far more than a passing glance. Standing serenely against the choppy waters of New York Harbor, it has watched generations arrive with dreams far larger than their luggage. Even amid the elbows, cameras and selfie sticks, it retained a dignity that photographs cannot capture.

Then it was time to hurry. After forty unforgettable days chasing football across North America, the

Timeless symbol: The Statue of Liberty rises above New York Harbor as ferry passengers pause to admire one of America's most enduring symbols during the crossing from Lower Manhattan. AP

